

The Partisan and Ideological Structure of Local Campaign Contributions

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Two competing views of local elections

- ▶ Unique: participation and dynamics ruled by special interests
- ▶ Maybe less partisan but definitely still partisan

Unsurprising takeaway: there is truth in both of these conceptualizations

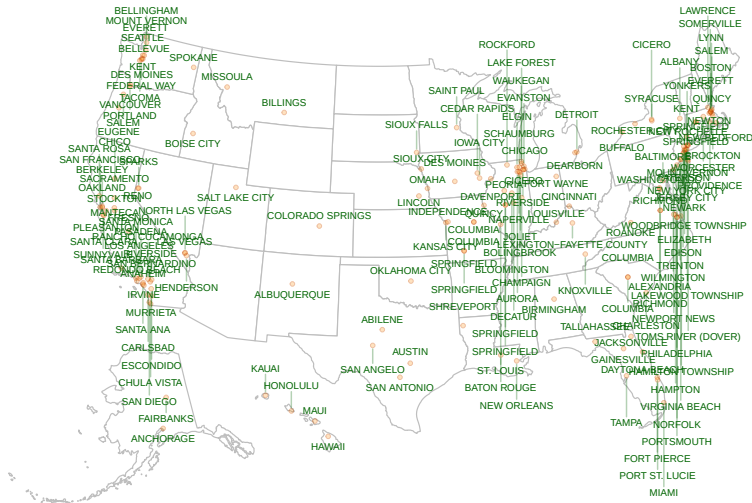
Two competing views of local elections

Partisanship and ideology as a first-order organizing force:

- ▶ Donors separate along ideological and partisan lines when the candidates have competing ideologies/partisanship
- ▶ When partisan competition doesn't exist (modal), the structure of interest \$ is more explanatory than partisanship

Data on campaign contributions in local elections

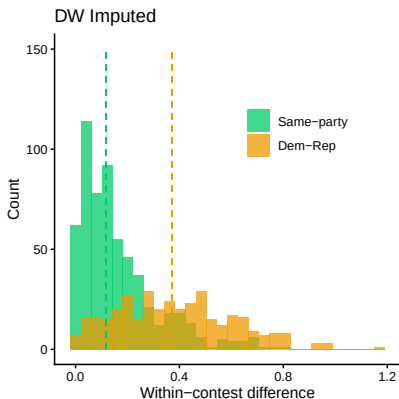
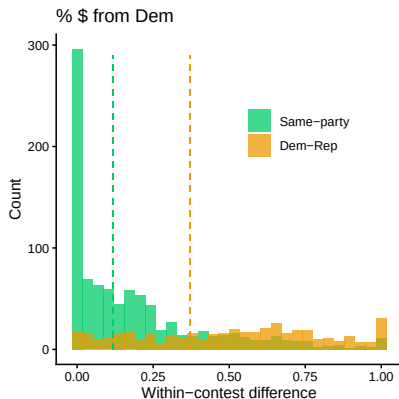
Campaign contribution data from > 150 American cities in 37 states



Full dataset

- ▶ Contribution level: who/\$ they give to, partisanship (L2), employment, contributions to congressional elections (DIME)
- ▶ Candidate level: Partisanship + ideology (Contrib to state/fed CFScores) (ALGE DB); Avg partisanship and ideology of their donors
- ▶ Contest level: *difference* in donor partisanship and ideology

Descriptive data is structured by candidate partisanship



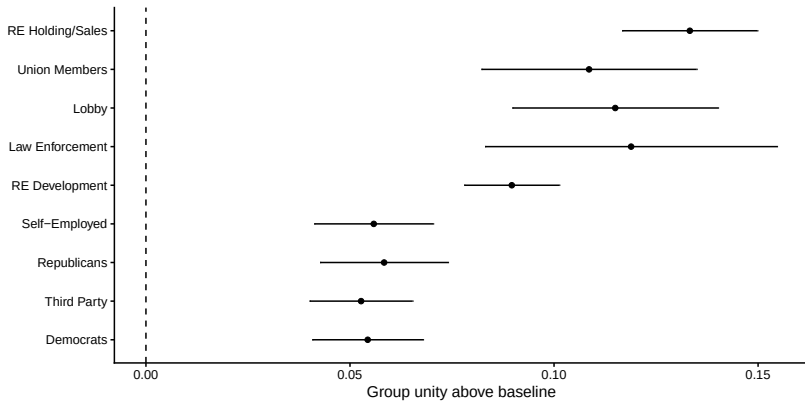
Evidence from within-city comparisons

When contests have the opportunity to be about partisanship or ideology, they are.

	D-R separation		Imputed DW diff	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Partisan competition	0.142 (0.018)		0.176 (0.013)	
Contrib CF difference		0.207 (0.024)		0.188 (0.016)
Municipality FE	X	X	X	X
<i>N</i>	1247	533	948	421

Partisanship vs interests

Interests are very unified



Partisanship vs interests

But this unity is lessened when candidate partisanship is at stake

	Probability prefer Candidate 1				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Grp unity*No PC	0.629 (0.040)	0.643 (0.046)	0.702 (0.088)	0.648 (0.048)	0.631 (0.036)
Pty unity*No PC	0.362 (0.047)	0.464 (0.062)	0.565 (0.119)	0.394 (0.066)	0.357 (0.042)
Municipality FE	X	X	X	X	X
Party FE	X	X	X	X	X
Subset		Fin comp	Pty/grp $\neq$	Open seats	Indep avgs
<i>N</i>	96842	53166	19718	45214	60658

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Grp unity*PC	0.219 (0.056)	0.346 (0.047)	0.364 (0.152)	0.215 (0.049)	0.279 (0.050)
Pty unity*PC	0.807 (0.046)	0.868 (0.037)	0.949 (0.077)	0.840 (0.038)	0.759 (0.052)
Municipality FE	X	X	X	X	X
Party FE	X	X	X	X	X
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Characterizing the role of partisanship and ideology

This paper asks how local CF dynamics related to partisanship + ideology

- ▶ Partisanship + ideology first (1/3)
- ▶ Then more local factors

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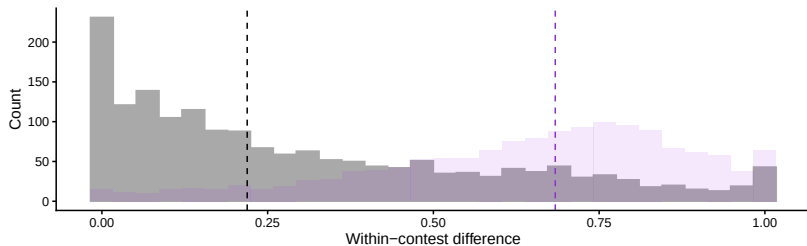
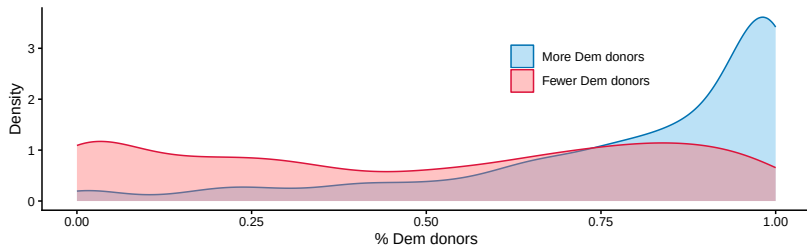
Candidate and contest-level attributes shape competition

- ▶ Importance of candidate, contest, and participant attributes
- ▶ Reconsider what "nationalization" means for the local level

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Descriptive data

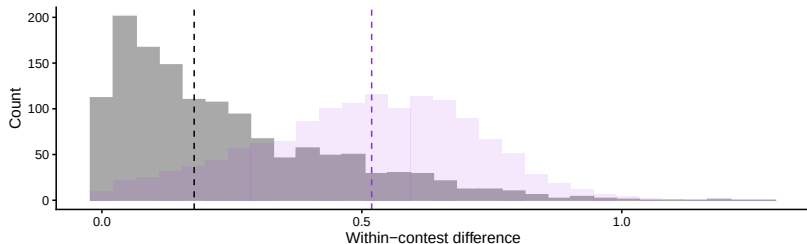
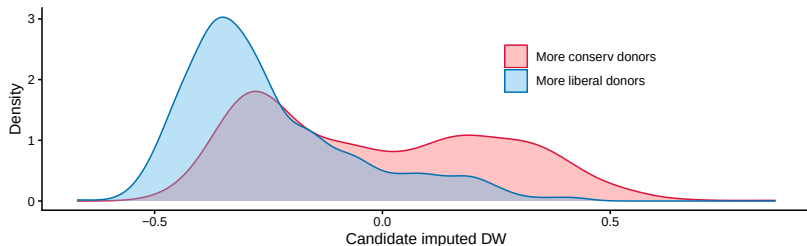
Substantial heterogeneity in the ideological/partisan bend of donor pools



Purple = state leg comparison

Descriptive data

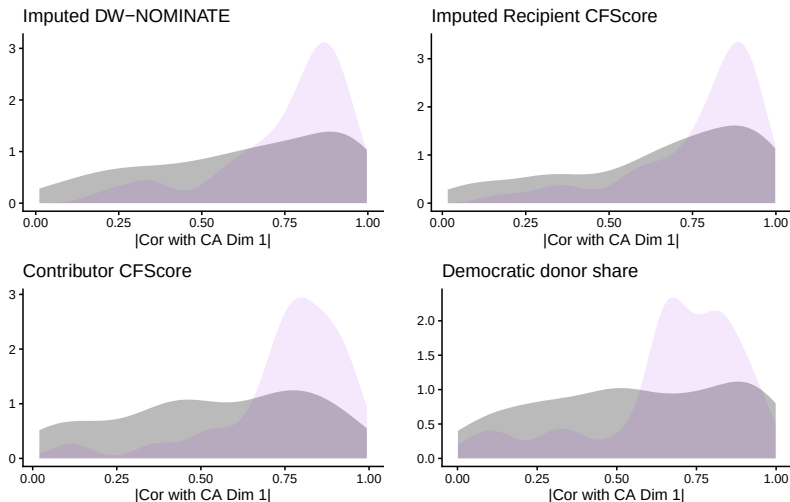
Substantial heterogeneity in the ideological/partisan bend of donor pools



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Descriptive data

Substantial heterogeneity in how the city-wide latent dimension of contributions is correlated with typical measures of ideology/partisanship



Descriptive data is structured by candidate partisanship

Cities with frequent inter-party competition have an underlying contribution structure much more like state races

